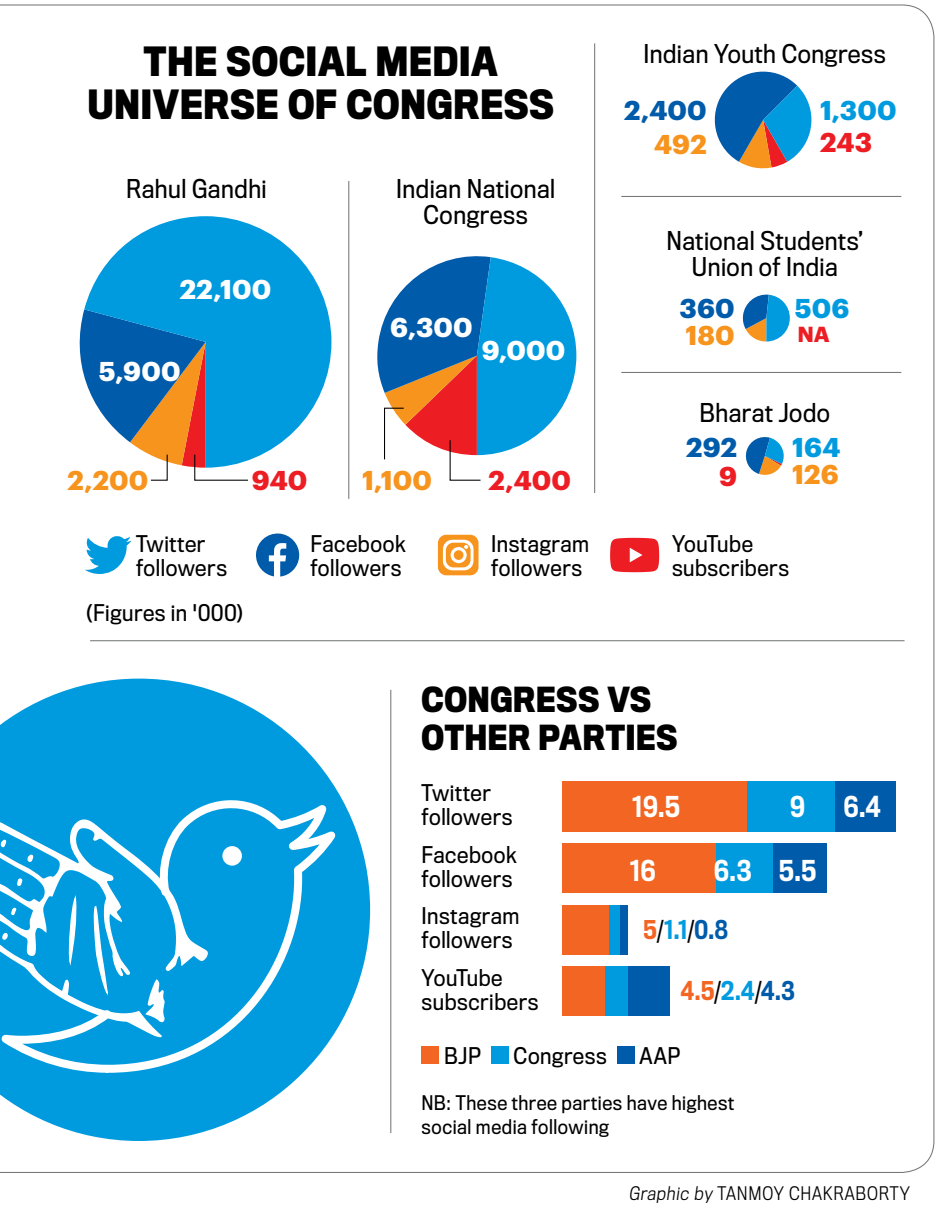


Graphic by TANMOY CHAKRABORTY

was filed after the PM shared a video of a girl seated with him who spoke in Gujarati about the BJP's governance. "We cannot be perennially at the receiving end of a vicious troll campaign. We will stick to facts.... We will not stoop to name-calling. But if they continue doing all this, they should be prepared for the same treatment. If they stop spreading fake news and name-calling, we will ensure that no one from our side indulges in it. That's the underlying principle we work with," says Shrinate.

Rahul Gandhi's personal involvement has also strengthened his party's social media campaign. Aided by the 10-member team led by Srivatsa, Rahul personally handles his social media accounts. That's the reason why, as a close aide claims, his posts are much less in number than those of PM Modi. For instance, between November 1 and November 21, Rahul posted only 55 tweets as against Modi's 214. "He is busy in BJY, and he can post only during breaks. That's why his frequency is less," reveals the aide, saying Rahul takes an active part in visualising and curating the content. In fact, the idea of posting videos of his informal interaction with party workers or drone shots of the yatra came from Rahul himself. "He wants the focus to be on people's participation and responses," the aide adds.

THE CONGRESS HAS BEEN TAKING ON SOCIAL MEDIA ADVERSARIES AGGRESSIVELY, FORCING THEM TO RETREAT, AND EVEN TAKING THEM TO COURT

People's engagement with and responses to Rahul's social media posts have certainly increased, particularly in comparison to PM Modi. An examination by INDIA TODAY found that between November 1 and 21, his tweets had almost double the number of engagements than those by Modi (*see box*). This despite the fact that Modi has nearly four times the number of followers. Another study by the Delhi-based Observer Research Foundation between January 1, 2019, and December 31, 2021, also found that engagements on Rahul's tweets were higher than Modi's. "Though we have not examined the latest data, the traction on video-centric platforms such as Facebook, Instagram and YouTube has seen an unprecedented swing, particularly after BJY," says a Rahul aide.

For maximum amplification of content generated from the yatra, "gentle instructions" were sent to senior leaders to promote such content. "We prepared a report on the year-long social media activities of 33 leaders and confronted them with it. They rarely amplified anything posted by Rahul Gandhi or the official INC handle. Now they have become active and aggressive," says a member of the communications team.

For additional support, in terms of professional hands and on-ground content generation, the party has hired Mumbai-based digital media outreach agency Teen Bandar. Apart from designing the logo and composing the BJY anthem, it maintains the website dedicated to the yatra. "Our permanent inhouse teams are small. For a massive exercise like BJY, we needed additional skilled manpower. Teen Bandar fulfils that requirement. It has no editorial say," says Jairam.